

01

The Three Jobs of an Ad Image

Document 1 of 8

New to this series? Start here — this document defines the vocabulary every other document uses.

CONTENTS

1 The Wrong First Question

2 The Three Places an Image Works

3 1. The Ad Image — Wins QUALIFIED Attention

4 2. The Advertorial Image — Confirms the Scent

5 3. The Jump Page Image — Builds Credibility and Momentum

6 Why Cheap Wrong Clicks Poison Everything

7 The Deeper Principle: Reader Warmth

8 The One Law That Ties Them Together: Congruence

9 How to Use This Series

10 Key Takeaways

The Wrong First Question

When a member drops an image in front of a coach and asks "is this a good image?", the honest answer is always another question: **good for what?**

Because there is no such thing as a good ad image in the abstract. An image that stops a cold scroller dead in a feed can be exactly the wrong image on a jump page. A photo that makes an advertorial feel like real journalism can be too soft, too composed, too "designed" to survive a native feed. The image is not judged against beauty, or polish, or even how much you like it. It is judged against a job — and the job changes depending on where the image lives.

So before any other advice in this series makes sense, you have to internalize the single most important habit in image selection: **name where the image lives first, then judge the image against that place's one job.** Skip that step and every downstream rule — faces, color, curiosity, composition — turns into folklore you apply at random. Keep that step and everything clicks into place.

This document gives you the map. The rest of the series fills in the terrain.

The Three Places an Image Works

A native advertorial funnel moves a reader through three places where images do work. Following the two common routes — native ad → advertorial → sales page, or native ad → jump page → VSL — those three places are:

1. The **ad image** (the image inside the ad unit in the feed).
2. The **advertorial** image (photos inside the article-style page the click lands on).
3. The **jump page** image (the short bridge page whose only purpose is to get a video playing).

Same campaign, same product, same core idea — but each of these places puts the image in front of a reader in a different state of mind, and so each one has a completely different job. Let's take them one at a time, from coldest reader to warmest.

1. The Ad Image — Wins QUALIFIED Attention

Your reader is at their absolute coldest here. They're scrolling an editorial feed in discovery mode — not shopping, not searching, not looking for you. They have hundreds of competing images sliding past per session, and their thumb is faster than their judgment. You have roughly a glance.

It's tempting to think the ad image's job is simply *clicks*. It isn't. The ad image's job is to stop the scroll for the **right** person and open a visual question the next page will answer. That word — right — is doing enormous work. An image that wins cheap, wrong clicks doesn't just waste money; it actively poisons the campaign, and we'll come back to exactly why in a moment.

To do this job the ad image has to read as **content, not as an ad**. One clear subject. Candid and unpolished. Nothing that looks designed, no text baked into the image, no pricing. The instant a reader's brain registers "this is an ad," the editorial camouflage collapses and the scroll continues. Success here isn't a big click number — it's a click from someone the advertorial can actually convert.

2. The Advertorial Image — Confirms the Scent

Now the reader has clicked. They've landed on something that looks and feels like an article, and in the first second they are unconsciously asking one question: *did I land where I thought I would?*

The advertorial image's entire job is to answer that question with a confident **yes**. It confirms the scent — the trail of expectation the reader is following from the ad image. Same subject matter, same tone, same implicit promise as the image that earned the click. If the ad image showed a weathered hand gripping a garden tool and the advertorial opens with a glossy studio product shot, the reader feels a tiny jolt of *wrong place* and starts drifting toward the back button, even if they can't name why.

So advertorial imagery stays in the editorial register: photos that could plausibly illustrate a real article, each one advancing the story the copy is telling rather than decorating around it. The reader is warmer now — they've demonstrated interest by clicking — so these images can carry more story than the ad image could. But they still can't look like advertising, because the whole power of the advertorial is that it doesn't feel like one.

3. The Jump Page Image — Builds Credibility and Momentum

The jump page (also called a bridge page) is the short page whose only job is to get the video playing. The reader who arrives here is at their hottest: they've invested real attention, they're leaning in, and they're one decision away from pressing play.

The image on this page can't lean on an article format for borrowed trust — there's no journalism to hide behind. So it works with the headline as **one unit**, and its two jobs are to make the promise concrete and to give the page just enough visual credibility to feel legitimate. Subject matter that makes the transformation believable, supporting the direct promise the headline is making, pointing all momentum at the play button.

This is also the one place slightly cleaner imagery is allowed. Trust elements can look a little more composed here — a jump page image doesn't have to look grabbed on a phone the way an ad image does. But "cleaner" has a hard ceiling: it never crosses into studio-branded advertising polish. Even at its most composed, the image stays believable, not slick.

Why Cheap Wrong Clicks Poison Everything

Come back to that warning about the ad image, because it's the reason "qualified" matters more than "maximum."

Imagine an ad image that tricks people into clicking — a jarring, sensational image that has nothing to do with the actual offer. It might pull a huge click-through rate. It also delivers a flood of people onto the advertorial who were never a match, who bounce almost immediately, who never read and never convert. To you that looks like a temporary win. To the native network's quality systems, it looks like an ad that sends garbage traffic to a page nobody engages with.

Those systems read poor post-click engagement and respond by throttling your distribution or repricing you upward — quietly punishing the whole campaign for the sin of one greedy image. This is why the ad image is not a maximum-clicks device. A great ad image is a **filter as much as a magnet**: it should attract the people the funnel can convert and let everyone else keep scrolling. Winning the wrong click is worse than winning no click at all.

The Deeper Principle: Reader Warmth

If you strip away the specifics, one idea explains why all three jobs differ: **the reader gets warmer at every step, and the image's assertiveness should rise to match.**

- A cold feed-scroller has no context and no patience. The ad image must communicate in a single glance and can't ask for anything but a click.
- A reader who clicked has demonstrated interest. The advertorial image has earned the right to carry more story.
- A reader who read the advertorial has invested real attention. The jump-page image can support a direct promise and push for the play.

Match the image's assertiveness to the reader's warmth and everything feels natural. Get it backwards — a hard-selling, over-composed image thrown at an ice-cold scroller, or a coy, mysterious image on a jump page where the reader is begging for the payoff — and the image works against the moment. Reader warmth is the principle underneath all the per-page rules you'll meet in this series. When a specific rule ever feels arbitrary, ask "how warm is the reader here?" and it usually explains itself.

The One Law That Ties Them Together: Congruence

Three places, three jobs — but they are not three separate assignments. They are three acts of one story, and the same visual idea must run through all of them. The ad image opens a visual question; the advertorial continues that exact subject and mood; the destination pays it off. This through-line is called **congruence**, and it's the thread the reader's scent follows from feed to video.

Congruence does *not* mean using the identical image three times. It means congruence of **idea** — each one re-expresses the same angle in the way its own job demands. The ad image's grabbed-on-a-phone shot of tired feet, the advertorial's photo of the same person mid-day at work, the jump page's cleaner image supporting the promise — different photographs, one unmistakable idea. Break the idea and the reader feels lost even when each individual image is strong.

That's the whole reason "is this a good image?" has to become "good for which of the three places, and does it carry the same angle as the pages around it?" Congruence is important enough that it gets its own full treatment later (see *Document 6, Congruence: One Idea Through the Whole Funnel*) — here, just lock in that the three jobs are always in service of one story.

How to Use This Series

Every document that follows assumes the vocabulary you just learned: the three places an image works, their three jobs, reader warmth, qualified attention, congruence. When a document teaches a technique, it teaches the concept universally and then shows you how it *dials* across the three places near the end — because almost nothing in image selection is a flat rule; most things are a setting that changes with where the image lives.

The companion documents go deeper on the tools: how expressive subjects and gaze direction pull the eye (*Document 2*); how visual curiosity and concealment open a loop (*Document 3*); what color actually does versus the folklore you've been taught (*Document 4*); why UGC-style authenticity beats produced polish (*Document 5*); congruence across the funnel (*Document 6*); the absolute compliance bans your ad images must never cross (*Document 7*); and the working process that turns all of it into a repeatable seven-step routine (*Document 8*).

Read them in any order once you have this one. But whichever technique you're applying, start every image decision the same way: **name where the image lives, name its job, then judge the image against that job.** That single habit is the foundation the entire series is built on.

✓ Key Takeaways

- There is no good image in the abstract. An image is only good *for the place it lives* — always name that place before you judge the image.
- There are three places, each with one job: the **ad image** wins qualified attention, the **advertorial** image confirms the scent, the **jump page** image builds credibility and momentum.

- The ad image is a filter, not a maximum-clicks device. Cheap, wrong clicks poison the whole campaign, because networks throttle or reprice ads whose post-click engagement is poor.
- The reader gets warmer at every step, and the image's assertiveness should rise to match — reader warmth is the principle underneath every per-page rule.
- One law ties the three places together: **congruence** — the same visual idea, re-expressed for each job, running through the whole chain (full treatment in *Document 6*).
- Whichever technique you apply from this series, start the same way every time: name where the image lives, name its job, judge the image against that job.